MANUAL // CBSE CLASS 12 ENGLISH CORE (FLAMINGO) // CH-08

GOING PLACES

A Study in Adolescent Fantasising, Class Limitations & Hero Worship by **A. R. Barton**

SYLLABUS: 2026–27 | FORMAT: PASSAGE-BY-PASSAGE MANUAL | SOURCES: NCERT + LITCHART + CBSE PYQS

TARGET: 100/100 BOARDS

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01. EXECUTIVE EXAM COMPASS & THEMES

THE PSYCHOLOGICAL & SOCIAL ARC

Irony of the Title: The idiom "Going Places" means achieving worldly success and upward mobility. Ironically, trapped in 20th-century working-class rigidity ("earmarked for the biscuit factory"), Sophie and her family aren't going anywhere physically—she only "goes places" inside her head.

Hero Worship & Self-Projection: Sophie's obsession with footballer Danny Casey transcends romantic crush; she sculpts him into her own equal ("no taller than you, no bolder than you") and attributes her boutique dream to him, using Casey as an alter-ego for unattainable success.

DOMINANT EXAMINATION THEMES (LITCHART + CBSE)

- **Fantasy vs. Reality:** Escapist dreaming inoculates Sophie against bleak home life, yet turns harmful when crossing into delusion at the canal bench.
- **Class Hierarchy vs. Ambition:** Working-class constraints make aspirations like boutiques appear laughable ("money grows on trees"), breeding cynicism in Derek and anger in her father.
- **Family vs. Individuality:** Cramped, steamy domesticity leaves Sophie alienated, seeking elusive validation from silent Geoff.
- **Limitations of Gender Roles:** Women like Sophie's mother ("crooked back") are crushed into silent domesticity, forcing Sophie to project her ambition onto a male hero.

SYMBOLS, MOTIFS & LITERARY STYLE

- **The Delicate Apron Bow:** Symbolizes idealized feminine grace crushed by back-breaking domestic servitude ("crooked back").
- **The Boutique:** Embodies autonomy, refined beauty, and class escape.
- **The Bicycle Outside the Pub:** Signals paternal escapism through alcohol and Sophie's relief at avoiding domestic interrogation.
- **Lofty Vocabulary Shift:** Plain gritty realism for home ("shiny and pink, smelled of soap") vs. elevated triumphant language for Casey ("thunderous eruption of exultant approbation").

SOCIOECONOMIC & HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Working-Class Ireland / UK Setting: Reflects rigid class stratification where working-class teenagers faced factory labor immediately upon leaving school, leaving scarce avenues for social mobility.

Gendered Restrictions: While young women entered factory work ("earmarked for the biscuit factory"), traditional domestic burdens remained suffocating—evoking "a tightening in her throat" whenever Sophie observes her silent, stooped mother.

02. CBSE GOLDEN KEYWORDS BANK

Incorporate these exact evaluation buzzwords and textual phrases into your board answers for full marks:

`Adolescent Fantasizing` `Hero Worship` `Earmarked for Biscuit Factory`
`Incongruity (Delicate Bow vs. Crooked Back)` `Escapism & Coping Mechanism` `Vicarious Acclaim`
`Class Hierarchy & Rigidity` `Gendered Limitations` `Lofty Vocabulary Shift`
`Words Prized Out Like Stones` `Shining Black Leathers` `Weekly Pilgrimage`
`Danny Casey as Doppelgänger` `No Taller, No Bolder` `Pangs of Doubt`
`Resignation Was No Sudden Thing` `Hard Burden of Sadness` `Bicycle Outside the Pub`
`Solitary Elm by Canal` `Exultant Approbation`

03. PASSAGE-BY-PASSAGE BREAKDOWN (01 TO 16)

Complete NCERT verbatim narrative chronologically sequenced across 16 passages, enriched with LitCharts thematic critiques, vocabulary, stylistic devices, and linked CBSE board questions.

Passage 1: Boutique Dreams & The Biscuit Factory Destiny

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *"When I leave," Sophie said, coming home from school, "I'm going to have a boutique." Jansie, linking arms with her along the street; looked doubtful. "Takes money, Soaf, something like that." "I'll find it," Sophie said, staring far down the street. "Take you a long time to save that much." "Well I'll be a manager then — yes, of course — to begin with. Till I've got enough. But anyway, I know just how it's all going to look." "They wouldn't make you manager straight off, Soaf." "I'll be like Mary Quant," Sophie said. "I'll be a natural. They'll see it from the start. I'll have the most amazing shop this city's ever seen." Jansie, knowing they were both earmarked for the biscuit factory, became melancholy. She wished Sophie wouldn't say these things.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Boutique:** A small, exclusive, stylish shop selling fashionable clothing and luxury accessories
- **Mary Quant:** Famous 1960s British fashion designer who revolutionized youth fashion (pioneer of the miniskirt)
- **Straight off:** Immediately, without prior experience or apprenticeship
- **Earmarked:** Designated, reserved, or predestined for a specific purpose or fate
- **Melancholy:** A deep, pensive, lingering sadness and quiet resignation

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Symbolism (The Boutique):** The boutique symbolizes everything Sophie craves: financial autonomy, glamour, refined taste, and social recognition beyond her working-class limits.
- **Visual Spatial Metaphor:** "staring far down the street" physically mirrors Sophie's tendency to gaze past immediate practicalities into distant, unattainable horizons.

- **Allusion:** Referencing "Mary Quant" reveals Sophie's romanticized delusion—she ignores that Quant held an art degree and came from a privileged background, assuming she will simply be a "natural."

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

Barton opens the narrative *in medias res* during a walk home from school, immediately establishing the central dichotomy of **fantasy versus reality**. Sophie's declaration of owning a boutique is not a naive whim, but a deliberate psychological refusal to accept her predetermined working-class destiny. When pragmatic Jansie points out financial barriers, Sophie seamlessly shifts her plan from owner to manager to fashion icon—demonstrating how seamlessly escapist fantasies adapt to bypass inconvenient facts. Notice Jansie's reaction: knowing they are both **earmarked for the biscuit factory** fills her with melancholy. For the grounded working class, even entertaining ambitious dreams is painful because it highlights the rigid **class hierarchy** trapping them.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Where were Sophie and Jansie most likely to find work after school? Why did Jansie become melancholy?

Model Answer: Both Sophie and Jansie belonged to lower-middle-class families and were destined ('earmarked') to work as laborers in the local biscuit factory upon leaving school. Jansie became melancholy because she acutely understood their severe financial constraints and knew Sophie's glamorous ambitions of owning a boutique were completely unattainable.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Earmarked for biscuit factory | Lower-middle-class financial boundaries | Jansie's pragmatic awareness vs. Sophie's escapist delusions.

Passage 2: Sensibility vs. Sophistication: Standing in the Rain

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *When they reached Sophie's street Jansie said, "It's only a few months away now, Soaf, you really should be sensible. They don't pay well for shop work, you know that, your dad would never allow it." "Or an actress. Now there's real money in that. Yes, and I could maybe have the boutique on the side. Actresses don't work full time, do they? Anyway, that or a fashion designer, you know — something a bit sophisticated." And she turned in through the open street door leaving Jansie standing in the rain. "If ever I come into money I'll buy a boutique." "Huh — if you ever come into money... if you ever come into money you'll buy us a blessed decent house to live in, thank you very much."*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Sensible:** Practical, grounded in harsh economic reality, prudent
- **Sophisticated:** Worldly, cultured, refined, and intellectually/aesthetically superior
- **Blessed decent:** Colloquial British/Irish emphatic expression meaning 'respectable and adequate'

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Atmospheric Symbolism (Rain):** Leaving Jansie "standing in the rain" symbolizes Jansie's grounding in damp, dreary everyday reality while Sophie retreats indoors into her mental shelter.
- **Dramatic Juxtaposition:** Sophie's lofty aspiration for something "sophisticated" (actress/designer) crashes immediately against her father/family's blunt utilitarian demand for a "blessed decent house."

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

Sophie's desperation to escape monotony intensifies as graduation looms just "a few months away." Notice her psychological defense mechanism: when confronted with poor wages in retail, she escalates her fantasy to acting and high fashion—careers perceived as effortless ("Actresses don't work full time,

do they?") and glamorous ("sophisticated"). Her abrupt departure, leaving Jansie in the rain, highlights Sophie's emotional impatience with anyone who threatens her dreamscape. Inside the house, her proud announcement ("If ever I come into money I'll buy a boutique") is instantly punctured by her family's harsh socioeconomic reality: a boutique is a frivolous vanity when the family lacks even a **blessed decent house**.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Why does Jansie advise Sophie to be 'sensible'? How does Sophie's family react to her dream?

Model Answer: Jansie urges Sophie to be sensible because leaving school is only months away, retail shop jobs pay poorly, and Sophie's father would never permit her to pursue an uncertain career instead of factory work. Inside, her family bluntly dismisses her boutique dream, reminding her that any windfall money should prioritize buying a decent house to live in.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Biscuit factory imminent | Poor shop wages & father's strict disapproval | Escalation to actress/fashion designer | Family prioritization of basic housing over luxury.

Passage 3: The Claustrophobic Home & The Delicate Apron Bow

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *Sophie's father was scooping shepherd's pie into his mouth as hard as he could go, his plump face still grimy and sweat-marked from the day. "She thinks money grows on trees, don't she, Dad?" said little Derek, hanging on the back of his father's chair. Their mother sighed. Sophie watched her back stooped over the sink and wondered at the incongruity of the delicate bow which fastened her apron strings. The delicate-seeming bow and the crooked back. The evening had already blacked in the windows and the small room was steamy from the stove and cluttered with the heavy-breathing man in his vest at the table and the dirty washing piled up in the corner. Sophie felt a tightening in her throat. She went to look for her brother Geoff.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Scooping:** Shoveling food hurriedly and ungracefully into one's mouth
- **Grimy:** Covered with ingrained industrial dirt, soot, and sweat
- **Incongruity:** The jarring mismatch or incompatibility between two things placed together
- **Stooped / Crooked:** Permanently bent forward from years of exhausting domestic drudgery
- **Cluttered:** Overcrowded, disordered, and untidy

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Visual & Olfactory Realism (Contrast in Register):** Barton shifts from lofty fantasy language to stark, gritty working-class realism: 'plump face still grimy', 'heavy-breathing man in his vest', 'dirty washing', 'steamy from the stove'.
- **Symbolism (The Delicate Bow vs. Crooked Back):** The 'delicate bow' symbolizes idealized feminine grace, while the 'crooked back' symbolizes how domestic servitude and poverty crush women's vitality.
- **Physical Manifestation of Suffocation:** "tightening in her throat" captures visceral emotional claustrophobia—Sophie feels choked by the sight of her mother's silenced, trapped existence.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

This passage exposes *why* Sophie escapes into fantasy: her domestic world is spiritually suffocating. Every sensory detail evokes working-class exhaustion—the father aggressively eating in his vest, little Derek echoing adult cynicism (“money grows on trees”), the darkened windows, steamy air, and piled dirty laundry. Crucially, her mother doesn’t utter a single word in the entire story; her sole expression is a weary sigh. When Sophie observes the **incongruity of the delicate bow** on her mother’s **crooked back**, she confronts a terrifying glimpse of her own potential future as a working-class woman. The physical **tightening in her throat** marks her visceral rejection of this domestic trap, driving her toward Geoff.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: What indicators of Sophie's socio-economic background appear in this passage? Explain the 'incongruity' Sophie notices.

Model Answer: The family’s lower-middle-class status is evident from the cramped, cluttered, steamy room, dirty laundry piled in the corner, her father’s grimy face and vest, and her mother’s exhausting kitchen toil. The 'incongruity' lies in the stark contrast between the dainty, feminine 'delicate bow' on her mother’s apron and her physically broken, 'crooked back'—symbolizing how poverty crushes feminine aspirations.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Cramped, steamy, cluttered kitchen | Grimy father in vest; dirty washing | Mother's silence and stooped back | Symbolism of delicate bow vs. crooked back | Visceral claustrophobia ('tightening in throat').

Passage 4: Geoff's Silence: The Allure of the Uncharted World

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *He was kneeling on the floor in the next room tinkering with a part of his motorcycle over some newspaper spread on the carpet. He was three years out of school, an apprentice mechanic, travelling to his work each day to the far side of the city. He was almost grown up now, and she suspected areas of his life about which she knew nothing, about which he never spoke. He said little at all, ever, voluntarily. Words had to be prized out of him like stones out of the ground. And she was jealous of his silence. When he wasn't speaking it was as though he was away somewhere, out there in the world in those places she had never been. Whether they were only the outlying districts of the city, or places beyond in the surrounding country — who knew? — they attained a special fascination simply because they were unknown to her and remained out of her reach.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Tinkering:** Attempting to repair, adjust, or assemble a mechanical device casually
- **Apprentice:** A trainee learning a skilled manual trade under an employer
- **Prized out:** Extracted with immense difficulty, as if levering something embedded in earth
- **Outlying:** Situated far from the central urban district; distant outskirts

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Simile:** "Words had to be prized out of him like stones out of the ground" — vividly illustrates Geoff's stubborn taciturnity and emotional reticence.
- **Psychological Projection / Motif of Silence:** Geoff's silence acts as a blank canvas onto which Sophie projects adventure, independence, and masculine mobility denied to her.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

Unlike her hostile father and silent mother, Geoff occupies an ambiguous space in Sophie's psyche. As a young apprentice mechanic commuting across the city on a motorcycle, he embodies physical freedom and **gendered mobility**. Because Geoff speaks rarely, Sophie becomes **jealous of his silence**—she misinterprets his natural shyness and quiet introversion as a sign of secret, glamorous adventures in distant territories. The unexplored spaces of the city acquire an aura of mystique precisely because they remain **out of her reach**. Geoff becomes her idealized bridge between domestic confinement and the vast outside world.

`[ CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC ]`

Q: Why was Sophie jealous of Geoff's silence? Explain the simile used to describe his speech.

Model Answer: Sophie was jealous of Geoff's silence because when he remained quiet, she imagined he was mentally inhabiting exciting, unknown worlds beyond the city's outskirts where she had never been. Barton uses the simile 'Words had to be prized out of him like stones out of the ground' to convey how painfully difficult it was to extract voluntary conversation from him.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Apprentice mechanic with cross-city mobility | Misinterpreted his introversion as mysterious adventures | Simile: 'prized out like stones' | Craving access to unreachable horizons.

Passage 5: Shining Black Leathers: Fantasy of Liberation & Applause

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *Perhaps there were also people, exotic, interesting people of whom he never spoke — it was possible, though he was quiet and didn't make new friends easily. She longed to know them. She wished she could be admitted more deeply into her brother's affections and that someday he might take her with him. Though their father forbade it and Geoff had never expressed an opinion, she knew he thought her too young. And she was impatient. She was conscious of a vast world out there waiting for her and she knew instinctively that she would feel as at home there as in the city which had always been her home. It expectantly awaited her arrival. She saw herself riding there behind Geoff. He wore new, shining black leathers and she a yellow dress with a kind of cape that flew out behind. There was the sound of applause as the world rose to greet them.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Exotic:** Intriguingly foreign, glamorous, out of the ordinary
- **Affections:** Warm fondness, emotional closeness, and fraternal trust
- **Forbade:** Strictly prohibited or banned
- **Cape:** A sleeveless flowing outer cloak symbolizing theatricality and heroism

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Color & Romantic Imagery:** "shining black leathers" (masculine coolness/rebellion) paired with a "yellow dress with a kind of cape" (vibrant femininity/triumph) creates a cinematic fantasy tableau.
- **Personification:** "a vast world out there waiting for her... It expectantly awaited her arrival" and "the world rose to greet them" reflects adolescent ego-centrism masking deep social invisibility.
- **Gendered Dependency (LitCharts Critique):** Even in her dream of freedom, Geoff drives the motorcycle while Sophie rides pillion behind him—showing she still relies on a male savior to escape.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

Sophie's longing to be **admitted more deeply into her brother's affections** stems from profound emotional isolation. Even while acknowledging that Geoff is quiet and doesn't make friends easily, she insists he knows "exotic, interesting people." Notice the striking visual tableau of her escape fantasy: Geoff in gleaming black motorcycle leathers, Sophie behind him in a radiant yellow dress with a billowing cape, greeted by thunderous **applause**. This reveals Sophie's fundamental psychological need—not merely wealth, but universal visibility and validation. Because she is invisible and dismissed at home, she imagines the entire outside world standing up to celebrate her arrival.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: How does Sophie envision her future alongside her brother Geoff?

Model Answer: Sophie fantasizes about being trusted deeply by Geoff and whisked away into a glamorous outside world that eagerly awaits her. She pictures herself riding pillion behind him on his motorcycle—Geoff clad in 'new, shining black leathers' and Sophie wearing a radiant 'yellow dress with a flowing cape'—while an admiring world rises to greet them with applause.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Longed for deeper fraternal affection | Imagery: shining black leathers & flowing yellow cape | World rising in applause | Desire for recognition and escape from stifling home.

Passage 6: The Fabrication: Meeting Danny Casey at Royce's Window

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *He sat frowning at the oily component he cradled in his hands, as though it were a small dumb animal and he was willing it to speak. “I met Danny Casey,” Sophie said. He looked around abruptly. “Where?” “In the arcade—funnily enough.” “It’s never true.” “I did too.” “You told Dad?” She shook her head, chastened at his unawareness that he was always the first to share her secrets. “I don’t believe it.” “There I was looking at the clothes in Royce’s window when someone came and stood beside me, and I looked around and who should it be but Danny Casey.” “All right, what does he look like?” “Oh come on, you know what he looks like.” “Close to, I mean.” “Well — he has green eyes. Gentle eyes. And he’s not so tall as you’d think…” She wondered if she should say about his teeth, but decided against it.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Cradled:** Held gently and protectively in one's hands
- **Abruptly:** Suddenly, sharply, caught off guard
- **Arcade:** A covered passageway lined with upscale shops and boutiques
- **Chastened:** Humbled, mildly hurt, or subdued by an unexpected realization

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Simile:** “as though it were a small dumb animal and he was willing it to speak” — highlights Geoff’s intense, quiet focus and gentle nature toward machines.
- **Verisimilitude / Psychological Manipulation:** Sophie introduces hyper-specific sensory details ('green eyes. Gentle eyes', height, 'Royce’s window') to lend deceptive authenticity to her fabrication.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

To win Geoff's undivided attention and breach his emotional armor, Sophie drops a calculated bombshell: "I met Danny Casey." Recognizing that Casey is Geoff's supreme hero, she exploits their shared interest to elevate her own status in her brother's eyes. Notice her hurt pride ("chastened at his unawareness") when Geoff asks if she told their father—affirming that Geoff holds a privileged place as her confidant. When Geoff demands proof ("Close to, I mean"), Sophie improvises astonishingly vivid details: his **gentle green eyes**, modest stature, and almost mentioning his teeth (holding back just enough detail to sound natural rather than rehearsed).

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Why did Sophie share the fabricated story of meeting Danny Casey with Geoff first? How did she make it sound believable?

Model Answer: Sophie told Geoff first because she deeply valued his trust and wanted to impress him by associating herself with his favorite football idol. To sound authentic, she avoided vague praise and supplied intimate, hyper-specific physical details—noting his 'gentle green eyes', modest height, and positioning the encounter casually outside Royce's boutique window.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Geoff as primary confidant | Desire to gain status in brother's eyes | Hyper-specific details (green eyes, height, Royce's window) | Restraint regarding his teeth to maintain plausibility.

Passage 7: The Father's Disdain & Warning of Trouble

ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT

Their father had washed when he came in and his face and arms were shiny and pink and he smelled of soap. He switched on the television, tossed one of little Derek's shoes from his chair onto the sofa, and sat down with a grunt. "Sophie met Danny Casey," Geoff said. Sophie wriggled where she was sitting at the table. Her father turned his head on his thick neck to look at her. His expression was one of disdain. "It's true," Geoff said. "I once knew a man who had known Tom Finney," his father said reverently to the television. "But that was a long time ago." "You told us," Geoff said. "Casey might be that good someday." "Better than that even. He's the best." "If he keeps his head on his shoulders. If they look after him properly. A lot of distractions for a youngster in the game these days." "He'll be all right. He's with the best team in the country." "He's very young yet." "He's older than I am." "Too young really for the first team." "You can't argue with that sort of ability." "He's going to buy a shop," Sophie said from the table. Her father grimaced. "Where'd you hear that?" "He told me so." He muttered something inaudible and dragged himself round in his chair. "This another of your wild stories?" "She met him in the arcade," Geoff said, and told him how it had been. "One of these days you're going to talk yourself into a load of trouble," her father said aggressively. "Geoff knows it's true, don't you Geoff?" "He don't believe you—though he'd like to."

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Wriggled:** Squirmed uneasily in discomfort and anticipation of backlash
- **Disdain:** Contemptuous scorn, dismissal, and disbelief
- **Tom Finney:** Legendary English international footballer (1922–2014), celebrated for loyalty and skill
- **Reverently:** With deep, solemn respect and awe

- **Keeps his head on his shoulders:** Remains grounded, sensible, and level-headed despite sudden fame
- **Grimaced:** Contorted face in annoyance, anger, or disgust

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[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Physical Characterization:** "turned his head on his thick neck", "sat down with a grunt" characterizes the father as stubborn, heavy, intimidating, and brutally pragmatic.
- **Psychological Projection (LitCharts Insight):** Sophie inserts herself into the male football debate by claiming Casey is "going to buy a shop"—projecting her own boutique dream onto a male idol so her family might respect it.
- **Idiom:** "keep his head on his shoulders" contrasts grounded maturity against the temptations of celebrity.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

When Geoff exposes the secret at the dinner table, Sophie physically squirms ("wriggled"), acutely aware of her father's intimidating temper. Her father doesn't even bother verifying the claim; his immediate reaction is **disdain**. Notice the subtle intergenerational clash: the father reveres old-guard legend Tom Finney, while Geoff champions young prodigy Danny Casey. Desperate to re-enter the conversation and gain validation, Sophie announces that Casey "is going to buy a shop"—subconsciously lending male celebrity legitimacy to her own mocked boutique ambition. Her father's aggressive warning ("talk yourself into a load of trouble") and blunt verdict ("He don't believe you—though he'd like to") expose the crushing skepticism Sophie faces at home.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Why did Sophie wriggle in her chair when Geoff announced she met Danny Casey? How did her father react?

Model Answer: Sophie wriggled nervously because she feared her father's short temper and immediate mockery, knowing he dismissed her imaginative stories as childish lies. Her father looked at her with open disdain, grimaced when she claimed Casey was buying a shop, dismissed it as another 'wild story', and aggressively warned that her habit of fabricating tales would land her in trouble.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Fear of father's temper and mockery | Expression of disdain and grimace | Aggressively labeled 'wild stories' | Warning of impending trouble | Father's realism vs. Geoff's tentative hope.

Passage 8: The Amber Glow: Escalating the Fantasy to a Date

ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT

The table lamp cast an amber glow across her brother's bedroom wall, and across the large poster of United's first team squad and the row of coloured photographs beneath, three of them of the young Irish prodigy, Casey. "Promise you'll tell no-one?" Sophie said. "Nothing to tell is there?" "Promise, Geoff — Dad'd murder me." "Only if he thought it was true." "Please, Geoff." "Christ, Sophie, you're still at school. Casey must have strings of girls." "No he doesn't." "How could you know that?" he jeered. "He told me, that's how." "As if anyone would tell a girl something like that." "Yes he did. He isn't like that. He's... quiet." "Not as quiet as all that — apparently." "It was nothing like that, Geoff — it was me spoke first. When I saw who it was, I said, 'Excuse me, but aren't you Danny Casey?' And he looked sort of surprised. And he said, 'Yes, that's right.' And I knew it must be him because he had the accent, you know, like when they interviewed him on the television. So I asked him for an autograph for little Derek, but neither of us had any paper or a pen. So then we just talked a bit. About the clothes in Royce's window. He seemed lonely. After all, it's a long way from the west of Ireland. And then, just as he was going, he said, if I would care to meet him next week he would give me an autograph then. Of course, I said I would." "As if he'd ever show up." "You do believe me now, don't you?" He dragged his jacket, which was shiny and shapeless, from the back of the chair and pushed his arms into it. She wished he paid more attention to his appearance. Wished he cared more about clothes. He was tall with a strong dark face. Handsome, she thought. "It's the unlikeliest thing I ever heard," he said.

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Amber glow:** Warm, golden-yellow, intimate lighting casting a romanticized atmosphere

- **Prodigy:** A young individual endowed with extraordinary, rare natural talent
- **Strings of girls:** Colloquial expression for a large number of female admirers
- **Jeered:** Mocked or teased in a skeptical, derisive tone
- **Unlikeliest:** Most improbable and difficult to believe

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Atmospheric Lighting:** The "amber glow" illuminates the shrine-like wall of Casey photographs, blurring the boundary between Geoff's hero worship and Sophie's romantic delusion.
- **Reality vs. Projection (Geoff's Appearance):** Sophie's observation of Geoff's "shiny and shapeless" jacket sharply contradicts her earlier motorcycle fantasy of "new, shining black leathers"—exposing how she beautifies reality in her mind.
- **Double Psychological Projection:** Sophie describes Casey as "lonely" and "far from the west of Ireland"—projecting her own profound emotional loneliness onto the celebrity.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

Inside Geoff's bedroom, bathed in the romantic **amber glow** beneath three photographs of Danny Casey, Sophie doubles down on her lie. Faced with Geoff's realistic skepticism ("Casey must have strings of girls"), she weaves an increasingly intricate narrative: she initiated the dialogue, recognized his Irish accent from TV interviews, asked for an autograph for Derek, bonded over clothes in Royce's window, sensed his loneliness, and secured a date for the following week! Notice how Sophie's description of Geoff putting on his **shiny and shapeless** jacket punctures her earlier leather-jacket glamour fantasy—even Geoff cannot fully meet her aesthetic ideals, yet she clings desperately to his belief.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: How did Sophie narrate the details of her alleged meeting with Danny Casey to convince Geoff? Did Geoff believe her?

Model Answer: Sophie explained that she recognized Danny Casey by his Irish accent from TV interviews, spoke first, and requested an autograph for little Derek. Since neither had a pen or paper, they chatted about clothes in Royce's window; noticing he seemed lonely, she accepted his offer to meet next week for the autograph. Despite her vivid details, Geoff remained skeptical, calling it 'the unlikeliest thing I ever heard.'

Marking Scheme Value Points: Spoke first; recognized Irish accent | Lacked pen/paper for Derek's autograph | Chat about Royce's window; projected loneliness | Agreed to meet next week | Geoff remained deeply skeptical.

Passage 9: The Weekly Pilgrimage: Triumph & Vicarious Pride

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *On Saturday they made their weekly pilgrimage to watch United. Sophie and her father and little Derek went down near the goal — Geoff, as always, went with his mates higher up. United won two-nil and Casey drove in the second goal, a blend of innocence and Irish genius, going round the two big defenders on the edge of the penalty area, with her father screaming for him to pass, and beating the hesitant goalkeeper from a dozen yards. Sophie glowed with pride. Afterwards Geoff was ecstatic. "I wish he was an Englishman," someone said on the bus. "Ireland'll win the World Cup," little Derek told his mother when Sophie brought him home. Her father was gone to the pub to celebrate.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Pilgrimage:** A sacred journey of devotion—used metaphorically for their fanatical weekly match attendance
- **Mates:** Colloquial British/Irish term for close male friends
- **Ecstatic:** Overwhelmed with euphoric excitement and rapture

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Metaphor:** "weekly pilgrimage" elevates working-class football fandom into a quasi-religious ritual uniting the fractured family.
- **Oxymoron / Antithesis:** "blend of innocence and Irish genius" captures Casey's youthful, unspoiled brilliance—mirroring the idealized image Sophie built in her head.
- **Irony of Vicarious Pride:** Sophie "glowed with pride" at Casey's goal as though she personally owned his triumph, while her father retreated straight to the pub.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

This is the ONLY occasion in the story where Sophie genuinely sees Danny Casey in person—from the distant stadium stands! Notice how football acts as the sole unifying ritual ("weekly pilgrimage") for this working-class household, temporarily dissolving domestic tension. When Casey weaves past defenders to score the second goal, Sophie experiences intense **vicarious pride**—treating his public triumph as private validation of her fantasy. Meanwhile, her father's immediate departure to the pub reinforces his recurring pattern of alcohol-fueled escapism, paralleling Sophie's psychological escapism.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Why is the family's Saturday trip called a 'weekly pilgrimage'? Which was the only time Sophie saw Danny Casey in reality?

Model Answer: Barton calls it a 'weekly pilgrimage' metaphorically to emphasize the family's religious-like devotion to watching United play every Saturday. This football match was the sole occasion Sophie ever saw Danny Casey in person—watching him from the crowded stands as he scored the second goal against two defenders.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Metaphor of sacred devotion to football | Sole real-life sighting of Casey (from the stands) | United won 2-0 | Sophie's vicarious pride | Father celebrating at the pub.

Passage 10: Jansie's Inquisition: The Terror of Exposure

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *"What's this you've been telling?" Jansie said, next week. "About what?" "Your Geoff told our Frank you met Danny Casey." This wasn't an inquisition, just Jansie being nosey. But Sophie was startled. "Oh, that." Jansie frowned, sensing she was covering. "Yes — that." "Well—yes, I did." "You never did?" Jansie exclaimed. Sophie glared at the ground. Damn that Geoff, this was a Geoff thing not a Jansie thing. It was meant to be something special just between them. Something secret. It wasn't a Jansie kind of thing at all. Tell gawky Jansie something like that and the whole neighbourhood would get to know it. Damn that Geoff, was nothing sacred?*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Inquisition:** A harsh, relentless, aggressive interrogation
- **Nosey:** Colloquial term meaning overly curious or prying into private affairs
- **Startled:** Taken completely by surprise with sudden alarm
- **Gawky:** Colloquial term meaning physically awkward, ungainly, and tactless
- **Sacred:** Deeply private, inviolable, and deserving absolute confidentiality

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Internal Monologue & Colloquial Rhythm:** "Damn that Geoff, was nothing sacred?" captures Sophie's genuine sense of betrayal and panic when her private fantasy leaks into the public sphere.
- **Character Foil Contrast:** Sophie considers the secret "sacred" and romantic ("a Geoff thing"), whereas "gawky" Jansie treats it as exciting neighborhood gossip.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

Sophie's private fantasy collides violently with social reality when Jansie confronts her the following week. Notice Sophie's visceral panic: she never anticipated her fragile daydream escaping the sacred, protective cocoon of her bond with Geoff. To Sophie, **gawky Jansie** lacks emotional depth and

discretion; once Jansie knows, “the whole neighbourhood would get to know it.” Sophie’s fury (“Damn that Geoff, was nothing sacred?”) underscores how deeply she relies on fantasy as a private sanctuary rather than mere neighborhood bragging.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Why was Sophie angry and startled when Jansie questioned her about meeting Danny Casey?

Model Answer: Sophie was shocked and furious with Geoff because she considered the story a special, private secret meant strictly for the two of them ('a Geoff thing'). She dreaded Jansie finding out because Jansie was 'nosey' and gossipy, and Sophie feared the rumor would rapidly spread across the entire neighborhood, exposing her lie.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Geoff leaked story to Frank | Private secret ('a Geoff thing') violated | Fear of gawky, gossipy Jansie spreading rumors | Panic over public humiliation.

Passage 11: A Sacred Fragment & Fear of the Household Row

ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT

"It's a secret — meant to be." "I'll keep a secret, Soaf, you know that." "I wasn't going to tell anyone. There'll be a right old row if my dad gets to hear about it." Jansie blinked. "A row? I'd have thought he'd be chuffed as anything." She realised then that Jansie didn't know about the date bit — Geoff hadn't told about that. She breathed more easily. So Geoff hadn't let her down after all. He believed in her after all. After all some things might be sacred. "It was just a little thing really. I asked him for an autograph, but we hadn't any paper or a pen so it was no good." How much had Geoff said? "Jesus, I wish I'd have been there." "Of course, my dad didn't want to believe it. You know what a misery he is. But the last thing I need is queues of people round our house asking him, 'What's all this about Danny Casey?' He'd murder me. And you know how my mum gets when there's a row." Jansie said, hushed, "You can trust me, Soaf, you know that."

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Right old row:** Colloquial idiom for a loud, violent domestic quarrel or uproar
- **Chuffed:** Colloquial slang meaning delighted, immensely pleased, and proud
- **Misery:** A chronically grumpy, pessimistic, and unpleasant person
- **Hushed:** Spoken in a quiet, solemn, conspiratorial whisper

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Dramatic Irony:** Jansie genuinely believes Sophie's father would be "chuffed as anything" if his daughter met a football star, completely missing Sophie's real terror of her father's violent temper.
- **Psychological Relief / Climax of Trust:** The repetition of "after all" ("Geoff hadn't let her down after all. He believed in her after all") reveals Sophie's desperate clinging to Geoff's loyalty.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

Sophie smoothly performs damage control while quietly assessing how much Geoff betrayed. Realizing Geoff omitted the secret date, she experiences immense relief—interpreting his silence as proof that **he believed in her after all** and that the date remains "sacred." Notice her hyper-realistic fear of domestic backlash: she dreads "queues of people" triggering a violent household "row" that would torment her fragile mother and provoke her father to "murder" her. Jansie's hushed reassurance confirms her loyalty beneath her gossipy exterior.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Why did Sophie breathe more easily during her conversation with Jansie? Why did she fear a 'row' at home?

Model Answer: Sophie felt relieved upon realizing Geoff had only mentioned the arcade encounter to Frank and kept the upcoming date completely confidential—proving some secrets between them remained 'sacred.' She feared a 'right old row' because neighbors lining up to ask about Danny Casey would trigger her grumpy father's explosive temper and deeply distress her already overwhelmed mother.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Geoff kept the date secret | Relief that trust wasn't totally broken | Fear of neighborhood attention | Father's violent temper and mother's fragile state.

Passage 12: The Solitary Elm by the Canal: Waiting for the Phantom

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *After dark she walked by the canal, along a sheltered path lighted only by the glare of the lamps from the wharf across the water, and the unceasing drone of the city was muffled and distant. It was a place she had often played in when she was a child. There was a wooden bench beneath a solitary elm where lovers sometimes came. She sat down to wait. It was the perfect place, she had always thought so, for a meeting of this kind. For those who wished not to be observed. She knew he would approve. For some while, waiting, she imagined his coming. She watched along the canal, seeing him come out of the shadows, imagining her own consequent excitement. Not until some time had elapsed did she begin balancing against this the idea of his not coming.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Canal:** A man-made waterway running through an industrial urban district
- **Wharf:** A level quayside structure alongside water where cargo ships moor
- **Drone:** A continuous, monotonous low-frequency humming sound
- **Solitary elm:** An isolated, towering elm tree standing alone as a landmark
- **Elapsed:** Passed or slipped by gradually (of time)

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Pastoral & Romantic Setting Contrast:** The “sheltered path”, “solitary elm”, and distant “muffled drone” create a secluded nocturnal sanctuary separated from the harsh industrial city.
- **Symbolism of Childhood Retreat:** Choosing a spot where “she had often played in when she was a child” underscores Sophie’s regression from terrifying adulthood into childhood make-believe.
- **Subtle Pronoun Ambiguity (LitCharts Insight):** “She knew he would approve” ambiguously hints at seeking approval not just from Casey, but from her skeptical brother and father.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

The psychological climax unfolds by the canal at night. Notice how carefully Barton sets the atmosphere: dim glare from industrial **wharf lamps** across dark water, the **solitary elm** framing an archetypal lovers' bench, and the city's harsh noise muffled into silence. Incredibly, Sophie's delusion has deepened to the point where she physically shows up for a date she invented! Initially, her imagination seamlessly animates the shadows with Casey's arrival. Only as silent minutes drag past does rational reality pierce the fantasy, forcing her to confront the devastating probability of **his not coming**.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Why did Sophie choose the wooden bench beneath the solitary elm by the canal for her meeting?

Model Answer: Sophie selected the secluded canal path because it was quiet, romantic, sheltered from public observation, and far removed from the muffled drone of the harsh city. Having played there throughout childhood, it felt like an intimate, ideal sanctuary for a secret celebrity rendezvous.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Secluded, dim lighting from wharf lamps | Muffled city noise | Nostalgic childhood play spot | Ideal romantic sanctuary for unobserved meeting.

Passage 13: Pangs of Doubt & The Gradual Weight of Resignation

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *Here I sit, she said to herself, wishing Danny would come, wishing he would come and sensing the time passing. I feel the pangs of doubt stirring inside me. I watch for him but still there is no sign of him. I remember Geoff saying he would never come, and how none of them believed me when I told them. I wonder what will I do, what can I tell them now if he doesn't come? But we know how it was, Danny and me — that's the main thing. How can you help what people choose to believe? But all the same, it makes me despondent, this knowing I'll never be able to show them they're wrong to doubt me. She waited, measuring in this way the changes taking place in her. Resignation was no sudden thing.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Pangs of doubt:** Sudden, sharp psychological stabs of anxiety and uncertainty
- **Despondent:** In low spirits from profound loss of hope, courage, or validation
- **Resignation:** The reluctant, heavy acceptance of an inescapable bitter truth

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Internal Monologue & Repetition:** "wishing Danny would come, wishing he would come" conveys rhythmic emotional desperation as seconds tick away.
- **Aphoristic Observation:** "Resignation was no sudden thing." — encapsulates how deeply ingrained illusions unravel slowly and painfully rather than instantaneously.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

This interior monologue reveals a stunning psychological truth: Sophie's despair is NOT that she feels romantically stood up by Danny Casey. Rather, her heart breaks over the imminent humiliation in front of her family: **knowing I'll never be able to show them they're wrong to doubt me**. Her fabricated romance was fundamentally a desperate bid to prove her personal worth to Geoff and her father. When

she whispers “But we know how it was, Danny and me,” she fights to preserve her dignity against disbelief. The iconic line **“Resignation was no sudden thing”** traces the agonizingly gradual collapse of self-deception.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Explain the significance of the line: 'Resignation was no sudden thing.' Why did Sophie feel despondent?

Model Answer: The statement signifies that letting go of deeply cherished fantasies and accepting harsh reality is an agonizing, gradual emotional process rather than an instant event. Sophie felt deeply despondent not merely because Casey didn’t appear, but because she realized she would never be able to prove her truthfulness to her skeptical family, condemning her to permanent disbelief.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Gradual, painful unraveling of illusions | Pangs of doubt replacing hope | Despondency over family's disbelief | Inability to vindicate herself before Geoff and father.

Passage 14: The Hard Burden of Sadness & The Bicycle Outside the Pub

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *Now I have become sad, she thought. And it is a hard burden to carry, this sadness. Sitting here waiting and knowing he will not come I can see the future and how I will have to live with this burden. They of course will doubt me, as they always doubted me, but I will have to hold up my head remembering how it was. Already I envisage the slow walk home, and Geoff's disappointed face when I tell him, "He didn't come, that Danny." And then he'll fly out and slam the door. "But we know how it was," I shall tell myself, "Danny and me." It is a hard thing, this sadness. She climbed the crumbling steps to the street. Outside the pub she passed her father's bicycle propped against the wall, and was glad. He would not be there when she got home.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Burden:** An oppressive, heavy emotional load one is forced to endure
- **Envisage:** To foresee, picture, or visualize a future scenario mentally
- **Crumbling:** Decaying, eroding, and breaking into fragile fragments
- **Propped:** Leaned or supported upright against a solid surface

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Physical Decay Mirroring Disillusionment:** "crumbling steps" visually reinforces the crumbling of her fragile fantasy as she ascends back into grim working-class reality.
- **Poignant Irony (The Bicycle Outside the Pub):** Passing her father's bicycle outside the pub (signaling he is drinking again) brings Sophie relief rather than shame—revealing how oppressive her home is.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

Sophie confronts the stark existential cost of her dreams: **it is a hard burden to carry, this sadness**. She visualizes the bleak future awaiting her—a lifetime of being dismissed ("they of course will doubt me"), Geoff's quiet disappointment, and having to defend an invisible truth solely inside her head ("But we know how it was"). Yet as she climbs the **crumbling steps** back into reality, the stark contrast between her fantasy and her real home life becomes undeniable: seeing her father's bicycle propped outside a pub makes her genuinely *glad* because she can escape his harsh interrogation tonight.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Why was Sophie glad to see her father's bicycle propped outside the pub? What 'burden' does she refer to?

Model Answer: Seeing her father's bicycle outside the pub meant he was away drinking and would not be at home to mock, scold, or interrogate her about Danny Casey's absence. The 'hard burden' refers to the crushing, lifelong emotional sadness of carrying unprovable dreams while enduring relentless skepticism from her family.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Father away drinking at pub | Relief at avoiding harsh domestic confrontation | 'Burden' of disillusionment and isolation | Foreseeing lifelong skepticism from family.

Passage 15: The Second-Person Reverie: Casey as Sophie's Doppelgänger

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *"Excuse me, but aren't you Danny Casey?" Coming through the arcade she pictured him again outside Royce's. He turns, reddening slightly. "Yes, that's right." "I watch you every week, with my dad and my brothers. We think you're great." "Oh, well now — that's very nice." "I wonder — would you mind signing an autograph?" His eyes are on the same level as your own. His nose is freckled and turns upwards slightly, and when he smiles he does so shyly, exposing teeth with gaps between. His eyes are green, and when he looks straight at you they seem to shimmer. They seem gentle, almost afraid. Like a gazelle's. And you look away. You let his eyes run over you a little. And then you come back to find them, slightly breathless.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Reddening:** Blushing faintly with shy, modest embarrassment
- **Freckled:** Dotted with small light-brown pigment spots on the nose/face
- **Shimmer:** To shine with a soft, wavering, gentle luminescence
- **Gazelle:** A graceful, swift, timid antelope known for large expressive eyes

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Shift to Second-Person ('You') & Present Tense:** Switching from third-person past ('she sat') to intimate second-person present ('His eyes are on the same level as your own... you look away') pulls the reader directly inside Sophie's waking trance.
- **Simile:** "Like a gazelle's" — feminizes Casey, portraying the tough athletic star as gentle, shy, and approachable.
- **Doppelgänger / Self-Projection (LitCharts Insight):** "His eyes are on the same level as your own" establishes physical parity—Casey is sculpted into Sophie's mirror image.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

Unable to endure the bleakness of her father's world, Sophie walks past Royce's boutique and slips instantly back into **escapist reverie**. Barton executes a brilliant stylistic shift here: moving into the immediate **present tense** and intimate **second-person perspective ("you")**, recreating the exact hallucination she originally described to Geoff. Notice how she subconsciously feminizes and softens the football prodigy—blushing shyly, freckles, gapped teeth, eyes shimmering "like a gazelle's," standing at her exact eye level. Casey is molded into a safe, non-threatening mirror of Sophie herself.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: How does Sophie's mental picture of Danny Casey blur the boundary between reality and fantasy at the arcade?

Model Answer: Walking past Royce's window after waiting in vain at the canal, Sophie slips effortlessly back into her invented dialogue in the present tense. She visualizes Casey blushing shyly, smiling with gapped teeth, and gazing at her with gentle green eyes 'like a gazelle's'—completely erasing the pain of her real-world disappointment.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Retreat back into fantasy outside Royce's | Shift to immediate present tense and 'you' | Simile: gentle eyes 'like a gazelle's' | Psychological defense mechanism against grim reality.

Passage 16: The Climax of Projection: Thunderous Exultant Approbation

> ORIGINAL VERBATIM TEXT
>
> *And he says, "I don't seem to have a pen at all." You realise you haven't either. "My brothers will be very sorry," you say. And afterwards you wait there alone in the arcade for a long while, standing where he stood, remembering the soft melodious voice, the shimmer of green eyes. No taller than you. No bolder than you. The prodigy. The innocent genius. The great Danny Casey. And she saw it all again, last Saturday — saw him ghost past the lumbering defenders, heard the fifty thousand catch their breath as he hovered momentarily over the ball, and then the explosion of sound as he struck it crisply into the goal, the sudden thunderous eruption of exultant approbation.*

[VOCABULARY & PHRASES]

- **Melodious:** Sweet-sounding, musical, and soothing to listen to
- **Ghost past:** To glide silently, effortlessly, and elusively past obstacles like an apparition
- **Lumbering:** Moving in a slow, heavy, clumsy, and awkward manner
- **Hovered:** Paused or remained poised motionless in mid-air/motion for a split second
- **Exultant approbation:** Triumphant, jubilant, overwhelming public praise and approval

[LITERARY & STYLISTIC DEVICES]

- **Metaphor (Sport as Spectral Grace):** "ghost past the lumbering defenders" contrasts effortless athletic genius against heavy, clumsy reality.
- **Lofty Climactic Register (LitCharts Insight):** The story closes on a dramatic lexical crescendo —"sudden thunderous eruption of exultant approbation"—demonstrating how Sophie's elevated vocabulary reflects her yearning for triumphant acclaim.
- **Identity Projection:** "No taller than you. No bolder than you. The prodigy." explicitly confirms that Danny Casey functions as Sophie's idealized alter-ego.

[LITERARY & PSYCHOLOGICAL ANALYSIS]

The concluding passage delivers the profound psychological key to the entire story. Even inside her fantasy, neither Sophie nor Danny possesses a pen—leaving her brothers perpetually without proof. Standing alone in the arcade, Sophie explicitly equates herself with the icon: **"No taller than you. No bolder than you. The prodigy."** In an entrenched class and gender hierarchy that denies working-class young women avenues to glory, Danny Casey becomes the vessel through which Sophie vicariously experiences success. The final memory of Casey gliding past **lumbering defenders** to a **thunderous eruption of exultant approbation** leaves Sophie suspended in the bittersweet warmth of an unattainable dream—trapped on earth, yet fiercely alive in her mind.

[CBSE EXAM VALUE POINTS & RTC]

Q: Explain the significance of the concluding lines: 'No taller than you. No bolder than you' and 'thunderous eruption of exultant approbation'.

Model Answer: By describing Danny Casey as 'no taller' and 'no bolder' than herself, Sophie unconsciously reveals that Casey is a psychological projection of her own latent desires for greatness. Living in a restrictive working-class society, she vicariously relives his triumphant goal and the crowd's 'thunderous eruption of exultant approbation' because she cannot envision achieving such glory in her own real life.

Marking Scheme Value Points: Casey as Sophie's alter-ego/projection | 'No taller, no bolder' implies parity | Lofty vocabulary ('exultant approbation') vs. grim home speech | Fantasy as permanent psychological refuge.

04. MASTER CHARACTER SKETCHES & PSYCHOLOGICAL PROFILES

1. SOPHIE (THE PROTAGONIST & INCURABLE DREAMER)

Archetype: The Escapist Idealist / The Rebel Against Class Rigidity

- **Impractical & Escapist:** Living in a cramped, cluttered working-class home and "earmarked for the biscuit factory," Sophie refuses to surrender to dreary reality, escaping into lofty dreams of owning a boutique, acting, or modeling herself after Mary Quant.
- **Hero Worship & Self-Projection:** Idolizes Irish football prodigy Danny Casey—not merely out of romantic infatuation, but by sculpting him into her mirror image ("no taller than you, no bolder than you") to vicariously inhabit greatness.
- **Craving Validation & Visibility:** Deeply alienated by her skeptical father and exhausted mother, she fabricates the Casey rendezvous primarily to prove her worth to her family and secure her silent brother Geoff's respect.
- **Tragic Resilience:** Even when disillusioned by the canal ("Resignation was no sudden thing"), she picks up her "hard burden" of sadness and immediately retreats into fantasy outside Royce's window to survive reality.

2. JANSIE (THE GROUNDED REALIST & FOIL)

Archetype: The Pragmatic Voice of Socioeconomic Reality

- **Practical & Realistic:** Fully aware of their modest financial limits and working-class destiny at the biscuit factory, Jansie constantly attempts to anchor Sophie with common sense ("Soaf, you really should be sensible").
- **Melancholy Resignation:** Unlike Sophie's defiance, Jansie accepts her social limitations—though doing so fills her with quiet sorrow ("melancholy").
- **Caring yet Gossipy ("Nosey & Gawky"):** Genuinely worried about Sophie falling into trouble or disappointment, yet lacks discretion when it comes to secrets ("the whole neighbourhood would get to know it").

3. GEOFF (SOPHIE'S ELDER BROTHER & SILENT CONFIDANT)

Archetype: The Stoic Apprentice / Symbol of Uncharted Freedom

- **Taciturn & Introverted:** Three years out of school working as an apprentice mechanic across the city; speaks so little that "words had to be prized out of him like stones out of the ground."
- **Symbol of Mobility to Sophie:** Sophie idealizes his silence as proof of an exotic, glamorous world ("shining black leathers"), though in reality he is a quiet, unfashionable homebody ("shiny and shapeless" jacket).
- **Skeptical yet Protective:** Initially dismisses Sophie's Casey tale ("It's the unlikeliest thing I ever heard") and warns her about celebrities having "strings of girls," yet tactfully omits the secret date when chatting with Frank.

4. SOPHIE'S FATHER (THE HARSH REALIST & ANTAGONIST)

Archetype: The Cynical Breadwinner / Enforcer of Class Reality

- **Crass & Intimidating Physicality:** Depicted with "plump, grimy face," "thick neck," heavy breathing in his vest, and aggressively eating shepherd's pie—embodying physical exhaustion and working-class cynicism.
- **Disdainful & Aggressive:** Has zero patience for Sophie's "wild stories," warning harshly that she will "talk yourself into a load of trouble." His disdain reveals anger at dreams that remind him of his own thwarted life.
- **Pub Escapism:** Reveres old-school football legend Tom Finney and retreats to the pub after matches, leaving Sophie genuinely relieved when she spots his bicycle outside the pub at night.

5. DANNY CASEY (THE IRISH PRODIGY & ALTER-EGO)

Archetype: The Romanticized Hero / Vessel of Vicarious Acclaim

- **Real-World Athlete:** A gifted young Irish football prodigy playing for United, praised by fans for his "blend of innocence and Irish genius" as he scores dazzling goals.
- **Sophie's Imagined Version:** Gentle green eyes "like a gazelle's," freckled nose, gapped teeth, shy voice, lonely far from Ireland, and eager to "buy a shop"—a feminized, accessible double of Sophie herself.

6. SOPHIE'S MOTHER & LITTLE DEREK (DOMESTIC SHADOWS)

Archetype: Trapped Domesticity & Inherited Cynicism

- **The Silent Mother:** Utters zero words in the text, communicating solely via a weary sigh; defined visually by the "incongruity" of her delicate apron bow against her "crooked back," symbolizing femininity crushed by domestic labor.
- **Little Derek:** Youngest sibling who parrots his father's cynical materialism ("She thinks money grows on trees, don't she, Dad?"), showing how class pessimism is transmitted across generations.

05. REFERENCE TO CONTEXT (EXTRACT-BASED QUESTIONS & ANSWERS)

CBSE 2023 BOARD EXAM EXTRACT

> EXTRACT
>
> *"Or an actress. Now there's real money in that. Yes, and I could maybe have the boutique on the side. Actresses don't work full time, do they? Anyway, that or a fashion designer, you know — something a bit sophisticated." And she turned in through the open street door leaving Jansie standing in the rain. "If ever I come into money I'll buy a boutique." "Huh — if you ever come into money… if you ever come into money you'll buy us a blessed decent house to live in, thank you very much." Sophie's father was scooping shepherd's pie into his mouth as hard as he could go, his plump face still grimy and sweat-marked from the day. "She thinks money grows on trees, don't she, Dad?" said little Derek, hanging on the back of his father's chair. Their mother sighed.*

Questions & Model CBSE Answers:

(i) Sophie wants to become an actress primarily to:
(A) compete with Jansie (B) earn real money quickly (C) support her father (D) travel across Ireland
Ans: **(B)** earn real money quickly (to fund her dream boutique).

(ii) What does Sophie's family believe she should spend windfall money on?
Ans: Buying a decent, respectable house to live in rather than a luxury boutique.

(iii) The phrase 'money grows on trees' spoken by Derek indicates that Sophie:
Ans: Is completely impractical and naive about financial realities and hard-earned income.

(iv) Sophie's mother's sigh in this extract is one of:
(A) delight (B) relief (C) weary helplessness (D) triumphant pride
Ans: **(C)** weary helplessness.

(v) From the opening interaction, Jansie comes across as a _____ person, while Sophie is _____.
Ans: practical/grounded; dreamy/impractical.

CBSE 2020 BOARD EXAM EXTRACT

> EXTRACT
>
> *"Here I sit, she said to herself, wishing Danny would come, wishing he would come and sensing the time passing. I feel the pangs of doubt stirring inside me. I watch for him but still there is no sign of him. I remember Geoff saying he would never come, and how none of them believed me when I told them. I wonder what will I do, what can I tell them now if he doesn't come? But we know how it was, Danny and me — that's the main thing. How can you help what people choose to believe? But all the same, it makes me despondent, this knowing I'll never be able to show them they're wrong to doubt me."*

Questions & Model CBSE Answers:

(i) Where is the speaker sitting while uttering these lines? Who is she waiting for?
Ans: Sophie is sitting on a wooden bench beneath a solitary elm beside the canal after dark, waiting for the football star Danny Casey.

(ii) What makes Sophie feel 'despondent' as time passes?
Ans: She realizes Danny will never come, which means she will never be able to vindicate herself or prove to her skeptical brother and father that they were wrong to doubt her.

(iii) Identify the phrase in the extract that means 'sharp stabs of anxiety or uncertainty'.
Ans: "pangs of doubt".

(iv) Which word in the extract is an antonym of 'optimistic / hopeful'?
Ans: "despondent".

CBSE HIGH-YIELD EXTRACT 3 (HOME ENVIRONMENT & SYMBOLISM)

> EXTRACT
>
> *"Sophie watched her back stooped over the sink and wondered at the incongruity of the delicate bow which fastened her apron strings. The delicate-seeming bow and the crooked back. The evening had already blacked in the windows and the small room was steamy from the stove and cluttered with the heavy-breathing man in his vest at the table and the dirty washing piled up in the corner. Sophie felt a tightening in her throat. She went to look for her brother Geoff."*

Questions & Model CBSE Answers:

(i) What is the 'incongruity' that Sophie observes in her mother?

Ans: The jarring mismatch between the dainty, delicate ornamental bow on her mother's apron and her physically bent, exhausted "crooked back" worn down by endless domestic drudgery.

(ii) Why did Sophie feel a 'tightening in her throat'?

Ans: She felt physically choked and emotionally suffocated by the grim, impoverished, steam-filled atmosphere of her house and the prospect of inheriting her mother's trapped domestic existence.

(iii) Why did she immediately go to look for her brother Geoff?

Ans: Because Geoff represented mystery, outside mobility, and a potential escape route from the stifling domestic enclosure.

06. HIGH-YIELD SHORT ANSWER QS (2 MARKS / 40–50 WORDS)

NCERT & CBSE 2024 // 2 MARKS

Q1. Why did Sophie long for her brother Geoff’s affection and feel jealous of his silence?

Geoff was quiet and introverted, and words had to be prized out of him like stones out of the ground. Sophie equated his silence with exotic, uncharted worlds beyond the city outskirts. Feeling trapped at home, she envied his masculine freedom and longed to enter his affections so he might take her along.

Value Points: Apprenticed mechanic commuting across city | Silent, mysterious persona | Sophie projected adventure onto his silence | Longed for escape and fraternal acceptance.

CBSE 2024 // 2 MARKS

Q2. Contrast the characters of Sophie and Jansie. Why did Jansie urge Sophie to be 'sensible'?

Sophie is an incorrigible daydreamer who aspires to own boutiques or act, oblivious to poverty. In contrast, Jansie is grounded, practical, and resigned to their working-class fate. Knowing both are "earmarked for the biscuit factory" and that Sophie's father would forbid shop work, Jansie urges her to avoid bitter future disappointment.

Value Points: Dreamer vs. Realist | Earmarked for biscuit factory | Poor wages & father's refusal | Protecting Sophie from disillusionment.

CBSE 2025 // 2 MARKS

Q3. “One of these days you’re going to talk yourself into a load of trouble.” What does this reveal about Sophie’s father?

This harsh warning reveals that Sophie’s father is a blunt, cynical realist with a volatile temper. Having no patience for Sophie’s "wild stories," he perceives her daydreaming as foolish dishonesty that will inevitably bring social embarrassment or serious personal trouble upon her and the family.

Value Points: Blunt, aggressive realist | Zero tolerance for wild fantasies | Fear of social trouble/embarrassment | Strained, unsupportive paternal bond.

NCERT // 2 MARKS

Q4. Why didn’t Sophie want Jansie to know about her story with Danny Casey?

Sophie considered the story a deeply personal, "sacred" secret meant strictly between herself and Geoff. She distrusted "gawky, nosey" Jansie, fearing she would spread the rumor across the entire neighborhood, triggering "queues of people" at her doorstep and inviting her father’s violent wrath ("he’d murder me").

Value Points: Private 'Geoff thing' | Jansie's gossipy nature | Fear of neighborhood rumors | Dread of father's violent household 'row'.

NCERT WORKING WITH WORDS // 2 MARKS

Q5. Explain the figurative meaning of: (a) 'Words had to be prized out of him like stones out of the ground' and (b) 'ghost past the lumbering defenders'.

(a) Suggests Geoff was extraordinarily taciturn and reserved, making conversation require as much strenuous effort as digging stubborn rocks out of solid soil. (b) Depicts Danny Casey gliding past heavy, slow, clumsy opponents with effortless, phantom-like agility and grace.

Value Points: (a) Extreme taciturnity requiring effort | (b) Effortless, agile speed contrasting clumsy opponents.

NCERT & CBSE 2020 // 2 MARKS

Q6. Did Sophie really meet Danny Casey? What was the sole occasion she saw him in reality?

No, Sophie never met Danny Casey; both the arcade encounter outside Royce's window and the promised autograph date were pure figments of her vivid imagination. The only time she saw him in real life was from the crowded stadium stands during the family's Saturday "weekly pilgrimage" to watch United win 2–0.

Value Points: Encounter was pure fantasy | Saw him only once from stadium stands | Weekly Saturday pilgrimage | United's 2–0 victory.

07. HIGH-SCORING LONG ANSWER & COMPARATIVE QUESTIONS (CBSE 5 MARKS / 120–150 WORDS)

CBSE 2025 COMPARATIVE QUESTION // 5 MARKS

Q1. Sophie (*Going Places*) is an escapist dreamer, while Franz (*The Last Lesson*) loves to miss school and procrastinates. Analyse how their escapist attitudes affect their lives.

Both A. R. Barton's Sophie and Alphonse Daudet's Franz exhibit a profound reluctance to confront uncomfortable realities, escaping into avoidance and illusion—yet both pay an emotional price for ignoring reality.

Sophie despises her suffocating, impoverished working-class destiny ("earmarked for the biscuit factory"). To cope, she invents glamorous ambitions of boutiques and fabricates a personal romance with Irish football star Danny Casey. However, her refusal to anchor her dreams in reality culminates in bitter disillusionment by the canal, leaving her carrying a "hard burden" of sadness and facing perpetual disbelief from her family.

Similarly, young Franz escapes the strict discipline of M. Hamel's French grammar lessons, preferring to hunt birds' eggs and watch Prussian soldiers drill. He postpones learning, assuming tomorrow will always be available. When Berlin's decree bans French forever, Franz suffers devastating regret over his wasted opportunities—realizing too late the priceless value of his heritage.

Ultimately, both narratives warn that while imagination and leisure are natural to youth, escaping reality without disciplined action leads inevitably to heartbreak and unfulfilled regret.

CBSE Value Points: Escapism from grim reality (Sophie: poverty/factory vs. Franz: grammar/discipline) | Consequences (Sophie: canal heartbreak & family disbelief vs. Franz: sudden loss of mother tongue & acute remorse) | Shared takeaway: Facing reality proactively.

CBSE 2024 COMPARATIVE QUESTION // 5 MARKS

Q2. Sophie (*Going Places*) lives in a world of fantasy. William Douglas (*Deep Water*) confronts reality and overcomes his terror of water. Compare the importance of disciplined action over mere daydreaming.

A. R. Barton's *Going Places* and William Douglas's *Deep Water* present two radically contrasting responses to crushing personal limitations: passive escapist fantasizing versus relentless, action-oriented confrontation.

In *Going Places*, Sophie despises her grim working-class house and factory destiny, yet takes zero practical steps to build skills or earn capital. Instead, she weaves hollow fantasies—expecting to become a boutique manager "straight off," an actress, or the confidante of celebrity Danny Casey. Because her dreams lack any foundation in real effort, they collapse at the canal bench, deepening her isolation.

Conversely, William Douglas confronts an equally crippling impediment—a traumatic phobia of water that destroys his adult joys. Rather than hiding in wishful fantasies, Douglas initiates systematic, disciplined action. He hires a professional instructor, trains five days a week for six months ("piece by piece"), and courageously tests himself in solitary open waters until his fear is completely eradicated.

While Sophie remains trapped in powerless illusions, Douglas achieves genuine emancipation—proving that youth must combine ambition with realistic strategy and perseverance.

CBSE Value Points: Sophie: Passive dreaming without effort/capital leads to disillusionment | Douglas: Active systematic confrontation (instructor, 6 months, Lake Wentworth) leads to freedom | Contrast between illusory escape and genuine transformation.

CBSE 2024 COMPARATIVE QUESTION // 5 MARKS

Q3. Both Aunt Jennifer (*Aunt Jennifer's Tigers*) and Sophie's Mother (*Going Places*) are silenced and subdued by patriarchal domesticity. Discuss the urgent need for women's empowerment.

Adrienne Rich's Aunt Jennifer and A. R. Barton's portrayal of Sophie's mother vividly expose how rigid gender roles and patriarchal oppression silence women's individuality and crush their vitality.

In *Going Places*, Sophie's mother never utters a single word of dialogue; her entire existence is reduced to exhausting kitchen labor, steaming stoves, and dirty washing, expressed solely through a defeated sigh. The "incongruity" of the delicate bow on her apron against her physically deformed "crooked back" powerfully symbolizes how domestic servitude crushes female grace and aspiration—a fate Sophie fiercely dreads.

Similarly, Aunt Jennifer suffers lifelong emotional terror under the "massive weight of Uncle's wedding band." With "terrified hands" fluttering through wool, she can express her yearning for fearless freedom only vicariously through the proud, prancing tigers embroidered on a screen.

Both texts emphasize that genuine social progress demands dismantling patriarchal subjugation through education, economic autonomy, and shared domestic respect so women never have to live through silent endurance or escapist art.

CBSE Value Points: Sophie's mother: total silence, crooked back, delicate bow symbol | Aunt Jennifer: wedding band weight, fluttering fingers, vicarious tiger art | Shared plea for education, economic independence, and dignity.

CBSE 2023 & LITCHART ANALYSIS // 5 MARKS

Q4. Is Sophie's fantasizing in *Going Places* merely foolish lying, or a complex psychological coping mechanism? Discuss with reference to the ending.

Through A. R. Barton's compassionate psychological lens, Sophie's fantasizing transcends simple deceit—it serves as a vital coping mechanism against suffocating socioeconomic confinement, rigid gender roles, and severe familial alienation.

Facing an imminent life in a biscuit factory, a verbally aggressive father, a visibly broken mother, and cynical ridicule from little Derek, Sophie resorts to her vivid imagination simply to keep her spirit intact. Her boutique dream embodies feminine independence; her fantasy of Danny Casey—whom she molds into her physical equal ("no taller, no bolder") and claims wants to buy a shop—becomes an alter-ego allowing her to experience triumph and acclaim denied to her in real life.

Admittedly, when her fantasy crosses into delusion at the canal bench, it inflicts painful disillusionment ("Resignation was no sudden thing"). Yet when she spots her father's bicycle outside the pub and realizes the bleak home waiting for her, retreating back into the cheering stadium memory ("thunderous eruption of exultant approbation") highlights how imagination remains her sole psychological shield against a world that refuses to let her "go places."

CBSE Value Points: Psychological refuge against factory fate and harsh home | Projection onto Danny Casey as alter-ego | Irony of title 'Going Places' | Balance between harmful delusion (canal) and emotional survival (final arcade reverie).

08. PREVIOUS YEARS' QUESTION VAULT (2019–2025)

Complete analysis of recurring CBSE Board examination questions and marking criteria from 2019 to 2025.

YEAR / MARKS	QUESTION ASKED IN BOARD EXAM	KEY SCORING CRITERIA
2025 (2 Marks)	“One of these days you’re going to talk yourself into a load of trouble.” What do you learn about Sophie’s father?	Blunt realist; impatient with wild stories; aggressive temper; worried about Sophie's recklessness.
2025 (2 Marks)	“Christ, Sophie, you’re still at school.” What image do you form of Geoff as a brother from this context?	Protective, grounded elder brother; cautions young Sophie against illusions about celebrity footballers with "strings of girls".
2025 (5 Marks)	Sophie is an escapist dreamer; Franz loves to miss school. Analyse the results of their attitudes towards life.	Comparison of avoidance/procrastination; Sophie's canal disillusionment vs. Franz's remorse at losing French lessons.
2024 (2 Marks)	‘Resignation was no sudden thing.’ What is the implication of this remark in the context of Sophie’s character?	Gradual, agonizing collapse of illusion; inner conflict between glamour fantasies and grim reality.
2024 (5 Marks)	Sophie lives in fantasy; Douglas (*Deep Water*) faces reality. Write an article on action over mere dreaming.	Contrast Sophie's idle escapism (boutique/Casey) with Douglas's structured effort (instructor, swimming drills).
2024 (5 Marks)	Aunt Jennifer and Sophie’s mother have been subdued by their husbands. Write an article on empowering women.	Patriarchal domestic crushing ('crooked back' vs. 'wedding band'); need for economic autonomy and respect.

YEAR / MARKS	QUESTION ASKED IN BOARD EXAM	KEY SCORING CRITERIA
2024 (5 Marks)	Umberto Eco (*The Interview*) advises Danny Casey on managing sudden popularity and time effectively.	Applying Eco's 'interstices' and discipline philosophy to help Casey balance football practice with public fame.
2023 (Extract 6M)	Read extract: "Or an actress. Now there's real money in that..." (Acting for money, house priority, mother's sigh).	Realism vs. fantasy; mother's sigh of helplessness; Jansie's practicality; Derek's parroted cynicism.
2023 (5 Marks)	Fantasising and unrealistic dreams sometimes lead to disappointment and disillusionment. Discuss with reference to Sophie.	Escalating lies from boutique to Casey date; heartbreak at canal bench; danger of ungrounded aspirations.
2020 (Extract 4M)	Read extract: "Here I sit, she said to herself, wishing Danny would come..." (Pangs of doubt, despondency).	Canal wait; 'pangs of doubt' vs. certainty; despondent over family's permanent disbelief.

END OF MANUAL // CBSE CLASS 12 ENGLISH CORE // CHAPTER 8: GOING PLACES

Synthesized from Official NCERT Text, LitCharts Analysis, SuccessCDs, and CBSE Board Marking Schemes.